American bases in Iraq and Syria. The possibility of a wider war seems closer than ever.

In the past two days, additional negotiations have taken place with Hamas regarding the release of hostages. Their demand: fuel for the enclave in exchange for hostages. A few moments ago, the Israeli military spokesperson announced that no fuel would be allowed into Gaza, which most probably means that something went wrong in the negotiations. Does it mean that the ground operation is on its way? We should know very soon.

The incandescent atmosphere that is spreading through Western countries is overwhelmingly pro-Palestinian. This leads to a series of questions. First, what is the role of overt, but mostly covert, antisemitism in this blatant difference of reactions toward the documented atrocities perpetrated by Hamas on the one hand, and the bombing of the Gaza Strip and the civilian casualties it entails on the other? Will we see the spreading of a new series of satanic images of the "enemy of mankind?" Will we hear and see that Jewish lives don't matter? It almost happened in Duisburg, Germany, where a would-be *shahid* reportedly planned to drive a truck into a pro-Israel meeting to kill as many participants as possible. He was arrested in time.

It is for this general reason that it never occurred to me to be a pacifist like my uncle Hans. He became a follower of Rudolf Steiner, and in 1939 reached Sweden, where he became director of an anthroposophical institution for youngsters with mental disabilities. He was a convinced pacifist and attempted, gently, to convert me when I spent a year, in 1956–57, at his institution. To no avail. I was totally at peace with my three years in the army and never thought that Israel could exist without a strong national defense. It has become more obvious now than ever. Unfortunately, we have always had a lunatic fringe for whom violence against the Palestinians was acceptable as long as they occupied the land "promised to